

Write Said Fred

Our beloved agent snoops around Lamington Road, investigating the price drop in CD-Writers

I upgraded to a 40 GB hard disk drive recently, but the data bloat has caught up with me already. My wallet doesn't allow me to buy a bigger hard disk, so I suppose it's time to invest in a CD-Writer and transfer my treasure of MP3s and DivX movies on to CDs.

We did a CD-Writer comparison for our February 2002 issue, but since then, much has changed. The writing speeds have almost doubled and prices have crashed to a point where you can get a speedy CD-Writer for less than Rs 4,000. The change is coming on fast and vendors are getting rid of older Writers at unbelievable prices.

The top CD-Writer speeds have nearly tripled since the beginning of this year, going from 16x to 40x, and 48x Writers are expected later this year.

Buffer underrun technology (which protects discs during writing) has become the norm, and the average price for a leading-edge drive has fallen

from Rs 7,000 to Rs 4,000 within a matter of months.

I've been trying to make informed decisions lately, trying to get the best buy within a reasonable budget, so it was with only Rs 5,000 in my pocket that I made a trip to Mumbai's Lamington Road.

I must apologise for being so Lamington Road-centric, but it's the Sensex of the Indian hardware scene—Lamington Road is where you can benefit from temporary price drops, market fluctuations and vendor dumping. For enthusiasts in Gawhati and Chennai, the benefits will take a little longer to trickle down.

The first brand that I came across was a 32x Krypton



■ The right brand of CD is as important as the CD-Writer. Cheap CDs might last for a few years, but for long-term storage, use brands such as HP or Sony.

■ CD prices have dropped as well; you can pay as low as Rs 12 a piece if you buy in bulk.

■ CD-R capacities have increased from 650 MB to a whopping 800 MB.

■ CD-RW (the CD re-writeable) is the ideal replacement for the floppy. RW media can be used up to 100 times and costs only Rs 120.

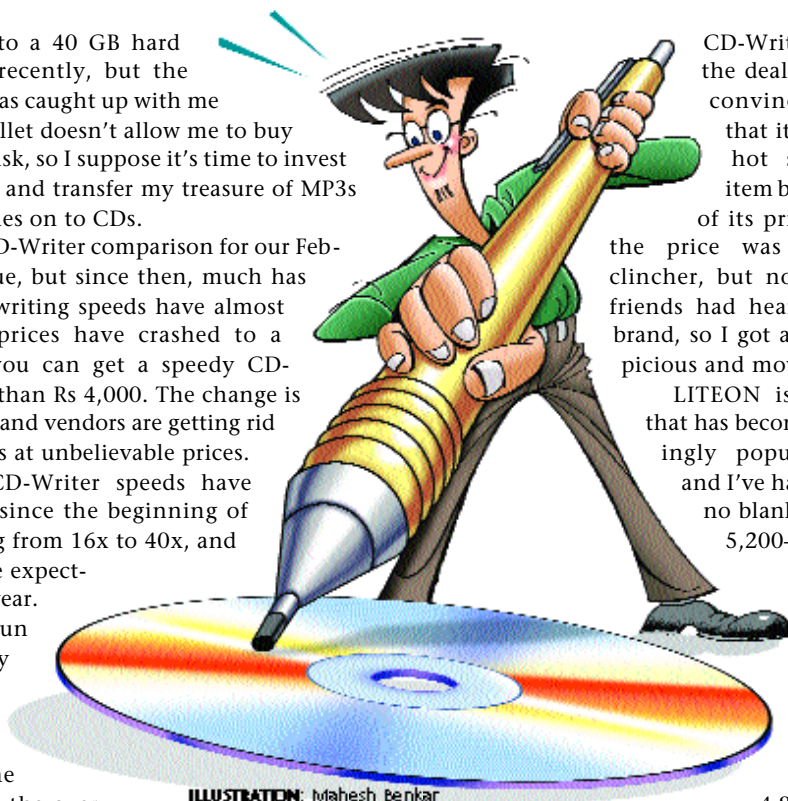


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

CD-Writer, and the dealer tried to convince me that it was a hot selling item because of its price. Yes, the price was really a clincher, but none of my friends had heard of this brand, so I got a little suspicious and moved on.

LITEON is a brand that has become increasingly popular lately

and I've had several reports that this Writer spews no blanks. I found a LITEON 40x Writer for Rs 5,200—definitely one of the fastest I've seen so far, but there's a caveat—as the drives become faster, the benefits shrink. A 24x might burn a CD in 3 minutes, but the increase in speed beyond that is negligible.

I found another cheap brand, Benq, which offered a 32x CD-Writer for Rs 3,900 and a 40x CD-Writer for Rs 4,800. I'd heard good reports of its burning

speeds. Sony's 40x CD-Writer is available for around Rs 4,000-4,500. And Samsung has a 24x selling for only Rs 3,200! Their 32x and 40x CD-Writers were priced at Rs 4,000 and Rs 5,200 respectively.

Next, I came across a Plextor, the mother of all CD-Writers—these drives come at a premium. Plextor is to CD-Writers what Rolex is to wristwatches. The PlexWriter W4012TA burns CDs at 40x (under 3 minutes) and was available for Rs 10,800. Their combo drive (CD-RW cum DVD-ROM drive) with 20x write and 12x DVD speeds was available for Rs 11,400. Plextor's 48x speed drive, the fastest drive I've seen so far, was for Rs 12,950.

Speed is not all that sells a CD-Writer; brand name is worth quite a lot, as is the brand positioning of the Writer. If you stretch your budget a little bit, you can get an SM-308 Samsung (8x CD-Writer cum 8x DVD drive) for a cool Rs 5,200. The SM-316 (16x CD-Writer cum 12x DVD drive) is available for around Rs 6,000. These models have been marketed as a three-in-one combo, and have generated a lot of excitement. External drives for the portable Writer cost more than Rs 10,000 (Benq had a 24x for Rs 10,000, and a 40x for Rs 11,000). Plextor's W2410TU external USB drive was going for Rs 15,000.

After a long day's work, I opted for the Samsung 24x—it costs only Rs 3,200 and meets my requirements perfectly. With stocks disappearing like hot cakes, now is the time to grab that Writer. Go get one before it's too late. 

ReWrite choice



An external CD-ReWriter used to cost nothing less than Rs 15,000, but you can now get one for half the price! The fully USB 2.0-compliant LITEON 24x10x40x external CD-ReWriter is available for a throwaway price of Rs 7,195.